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The Power of Power



Power, it is said, is the ultimate aphrodisiac. That is why former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda, the director of the theatre of the absurd in Karnataka, still lusts for it even in his sunset years. As INDIA TODAY's southern correspondent in the '80s, I recall one incident that perhaps best illustrates just what power is all about. In the 1983 state elections, the Janata Party surprised everyone by emerging along with its ally, the Kranti Ranga, as the single largest formation. In a state dominated by Vokkaliga and Lingayat politics, Gowda, a Vokkaliga and among the winning MLAs for the Janata Party, was a prime candidate for the chief minister's post. So too was S.R. Bommai, a Lingayat. The Kranti Ranga chief, S. Bangarappa, a backward class leader, also threw in his cap for the chief minister's post. To enhance his chances he even merged the Kranti Ranga with the Janata Party.

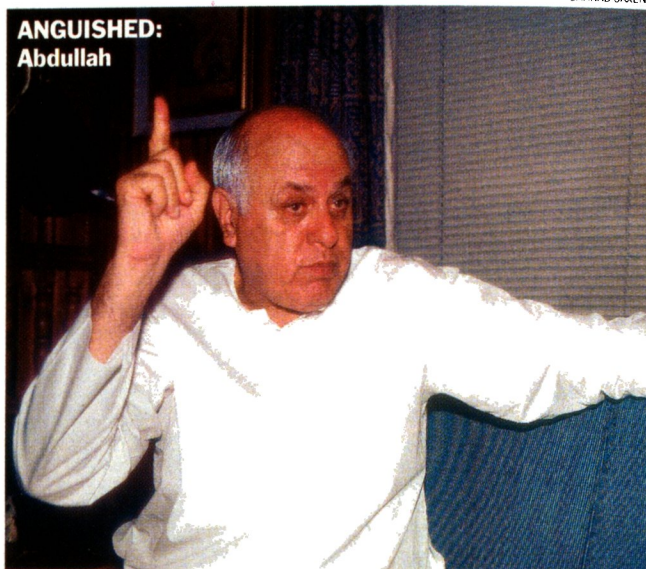
The late Ramakrishna Hegde, then a general secretary of the Janata Party, was called in to mediate. For some reason he allowed me to sit in his living room within earshot as he conducted negotiations with Gowda, Bangarappa and Bommai for the chief minister's post. There were heated arguments and at one point Gowda even objected to my presence. But Hegde waved him off and I remained seated watching this fascinating tussle. To get some privacy, Bommai and Bangarappa even went into the bathroom to confabulate. It was soon apparent that Gowda, Bangarappa and Bommai were cancelling themselves out—as neither of them wanted the other to become chief minister. It was then agreed as a compromise that Hegde would become the chief minister. At that precise moment, the air turned electric and the entire relationship between Hegde and the three contenders underwent a dramatic change. No more was Hegde one among the equals. Bommai garlanded him while Bangarappa and Gowda greeted him with folded hands and servility.

It was a defining moment for from then on Hegde would not only decide their fortunes but that of the three crore people of the state. Bangarappa was clearly unhappy as was Gowda but after some sulking they would come around. Hegde would go on to rule the state till 1988. Bommai, Bangarappa and Gowda would then become chief ministers of Karnataka. But that living room battle was an awesome demonstration of the true power of power.



SAURABH SINGH

ANGUISHED:
Abdullah



Speaking His Mind

SRINAGAR Former chief minister and the patron of National Conference Farooq Abdullah is known for speaking his mind on Jammu & Kashmir. He has often made statements which he has had to tone down or withdraw later.

On November 19, Abdullah put his foot in his mouth once again when he rued his father's decision to accede to annexation with India. He was responding to the killing, allegedly by the army, of Riyaz Ahmed Sofi, a baker in south Kashmir's Kulgam area. "The killings of two innocent people force us to think whether the signing of the instrument of accession by my father late Sheikh Mohammed Abdullah and Maharaja Hari Singh was fair and straight," Abdullah said in Jammu, the state's winter capital. The army claims Sofi was killed in a "crossfire" between the troops and the militants while villagers say it was a "cold-blooded" murder.

Massive protests forced police to register a

murder case against the soldiers. A month earlier, police had registered a murder case against the army for allegedly killing a schoolteacher, Abdul Rashid, in frontier Kupwara district.

Abdullah warned that if the Government did not pull up the army, it would eventually force parties in Kashmir to question accession to India. "The army is harming us and is weakening the stand of pro-India political parties in the state."

Many believe Abdullah's statement to be an anguished outburst of despair rather than a statement of intent. But going by the neo-separatist rhetoric other mainstream parties in the state—like Mufti Mohammad Sayeed's People's Democratic Party—have been using it to stay relevant, Abdullah may be looking at crafting new appeal to the voters in Kashmir with an eye on the assembly elections due by October next year.

by Aljaz Hussain